**SCHOOL OF HISTORY, ANTHROPOLOGY, PHILOSOPHY AND POLITICS**

## COVER SHEET FOR ASSESSMENT

A completed cover sheet must be included as the first page of each piece of coursework submitted for assessment. This can be achieved by inserting this page into your coursework file using the cut and paste function. Coursework **must be submitted electronically in either Microsoft Word or PDF format** to the relevant 'Assignment' section on the module's Canvas page by **12:00 noon on the day of the deadline**. Deadline dates are available on the module's Canvas page or, if applicable, in the module guide.

It is the student's responsibility to ensure they have sufficient time to access a computer and upload the essay online before the deadline. Coursework will **not be accepted in person or by post at the HAPP Office, nor by email to any member of staff**. If you encounter issues regarding the online submission of coursework, please contact your Module Convenor well in advance of the deadline.

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| Student Number: | 40537267 |
| Module Title: Modern Political Thought | Module Code: PAI2005 |
| Tutor's Name: Dr Jake Lehrle-Fry | Word Count: 1363 |

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- I declare that I have read the University regulations on Academic Offences, and that the attached submission is my own original work.
- No part of it has been submitted for any other assignment, and I have acknowledged in my notes and bibliography all written and electronic sources used.
- I have read the School's AI policy and have familiarised myself with my convenor's advice on acceptable AI use on this module.
- I agree to have my work checked using plagiarism software.

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| **Have you used Artificial AI software (such as Chat GPT, Jenni, Bard, etc.) in the production of this assignment?** | No |
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Berlin reading exercise

## Question 1

The negative sense of liberty for Berlin is what a person can do freely and to what extent they can do it without being constrained by others (Berlin, 2006, p. 369). It is about the area of interference, to what extent is a person free to do something. The concept of positive liberty contains the source of control over a person, specifically about what they should do or be (Berlin, 2006, p. 369). As I understood it means what are the factors by which a person decides what to do or what to become. Simply it means what is a person free from and what is he free to do, and what limits these two freedoms.

For Locke, freedom also means liberty from the consequences that result from a person enacting their will under the law of Nature[1]. He believes that this can be achieved by establishing laws that limit all people's natural liberty and that this, in turn, increases all people's liberty (1823, p. 114). These laws then ensure a singular person's freedom to do in his private life what he chooses. Berlin's concept of negative liberty is similar; it also speaks of the freedom from being infringed upon, but from what I understood his opinion differs when it comes to the connection between law and liberty. That is because, unlike Locke, Berlin believes that creating laws that would, in Locke's case, mean increasing your freedom, are not actually doing so because law is not about freedom, it is about restriction. He says: "*If freedom is sacred, untouchable value there can be no such principle"* (2006, p. 371). He later also quotes Bentham who says something similar: *"Every law is an infraction of liberty"* and he also adds that it does not matter if the sum of liberty is increased by these laws (2006, p. 381).

## Question 2

Berlin's argument about the connection between economic resources and freedom is that a person's economical status does not change the freedom that they seek. He dismisses the notion that there are more "types" of freedom. Freedom and the "range of freedom" of a person therefore is not based on a person's wealth.

He supports this point by arguing that the mere inability to do something because you lack the economic resources to do so, does not mean you are lacking the freedom to do it. *"If my poverty were a kind of disease, which prevented me from buying bread …, as lameness prevents me from running, this inability would not naturally be described as a lack of freedom, least of all political freedom."* (Berlin, 2006, p. 370). He is pointing out that this is not coercion or slavery, it is just an inability to do something. It is slavery only in the case of you believing that society is structured in a way that leaves you in that situation (Berlin, 2006, p. 370).

Although he acknowledges that a person, who's economical or social status prevents them from using their freedom as someone who's economical status is better, he dismisses the notion that this means that the unfortunate person is not in need of freedom or in need of some other kind of freedom. *"The Egyptian peasant needs clothes or medicine before, and more than, personal liberty, but the minimum freedom that he needs today, and the greater degree of freedom that he may need tomorrow, is not some species of freedom peculiar to him, but identical with that of professors, artists, and millionaires."* (Berlin, 2006, p. 370). Even though the peasant needs the basic things to start using his freedom, that does not mean it is justifiable to infringe upon a freedom of an other in the name of morality or justice because that would mean that his own freedom could be violated upon by the same reason.

[1] For example killing someone unjustly.

## Question 3

From what I understood, for Constant limited democratic rule is the right approach, because it is the only way a free person can keep their liberty. *"Political liberty, by submitting to all the citizens, without exception, the care and assessment of their most sacred interests, enlarges their spirit, ennobles their thoughts, and establishes among them a kind of intellectual equality which forms the glory and power of a people. "* (Constant, 1989, p. 327). Although he says that individual liberty is the highest liberty, he believes in representative democracy with safeguards and a vast area for private freedom. That is because in the past people gave away their individual freedom for this political liberty, which is an infringement on the negative liberty (1989, p. 323). This is where they are similar: both agree that negative liberty is important. Constant's belief in democracy is based on the combination of the two liberties though (Constant, 1989, p. 327).

Berlin disagrees that this is the case because for him the notion of democracy is based on positive liberty and not in the negative sense, as it is more about what I am free to do rather than who is the one telling me what to do. He says that if individual freedom is the focus, democracy might not be the best regime to do so. By this logic, bigger individual freedom can appear in other regimes that are not democratic if they have a benevolent leader (2006, pp. 372-373).

Berlin says that the logic of that there should be focus on elevating "*the largest possible number of citizens to the highest moral position … Institutions must achieve the moral education of the citizens."* (Constant, 1989, p. 328) is wrong. What the right moral education is should not be decided by the government, even if it is elected by the people. He refuses the notion that there is a moral truth and supports subjectivity and pluralism. *"The very desire for guarantees that our values are eternal and secure in some objective heaven is perhaps only a craving for the certainties of childhood or the absolute values of our primitive past."* (Berlin, 2006, p. 384).

## Question 4

Positive liberty starts by wanting to be the master of your own self. "*I wish to be a subject, not an object; to be moved by reasons, by conscious purposes, which are my own"* (Berlin, 2006, p. 373). As I understood the text, to be completely free a person must be rational, and to be completely rational means getting rid of the pleasures that one's natural self desires and of one's irrational nature. That creates the real self, which is guided by rational thinking and that can make a person identify the real self as something bigger than the individual, since if being rational ends in the one truth then everyone should be aiming at the same thing. If that is true, then that makes it right for a person to coerce others, because it is in the benefit of the whole and that individual themselves, which leads to the "collective" limiting or completely taking away the liberty of others (Berlin, 2006, pp. 373-374).

This theory at least to me is convincing. If a person, who believes that he is rational and that what he believes is righteous, is what anybody who is rational as well would believe, then it makes sense to limit other people's liberty because it is in their best interest. I can see this logic when I look at some of the extremist ideologies of the past century[2], but I myself believe that "coercing", as Berlin put it, other people to what I believe are the basic objective truths is not an infraction of my definition of freedom. I would also say that being rational in this sense does not necessarily have to come from a place of wanting positive freedom. There are ideologies that know that the end goal is not to increase freedom of a person or a group. I would say that his argument is plausible, but I think that in most cases authoritarianism does not come from the requirement of positive freedom.

[2] In my opinion for example Italian fascism, doing "good" for the sake of the whole because it is rational.

## References


1. Berlin, I. (2006) 'Two concepts of liberty', in Goodin, R.E. and Pettit, P. (eds.) *Contemporary political philosophy: an anthology*. 2nd edn. Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishing, pp. 369–386.

2. Constant, B. (1988) 'The liberty of the ancients compared with that of the moderns', in Fontana, B. (ed. and trans.) *Political writings*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 309–328.

3. Locke, J. (1823) 'Two treatises of government', in *The works of John Locke*. A new edition, corrected. Vol. 5. London: Thomas Tegg et al.